

helped many organisations shift from proprietary to open source infrastructure. One example is Rahuri Paper Mills (now closed). In addition, he professionally assisted several colleges and universities in shifting to FOSS. The UMIT (Usha Mittal Institute of Technology) department of the SNDT Women's University in Mumbai is one big success story, where KK and Prof. Shitole started the FOSS movement back in 2008.

KK has been conducting workshops and seminars in India and overseas on career opportunities in FOSS, as well as on MVC based open source frameworks like Django and Pyramid. He also conducts workshops on Python and related technologies, all open source of course.

The challenges that had to be overcome

KK's journey was not an easy one. "I met a lot of wonderful friends and mentored extremely talented students. I guess they would be in a position to teach me a thing or two now. But I had a lot of enemies also. Professional jealousy, extreme politics and several other factors exist in the open source world too," KK laments.

"Many believe that it is a sin to earn money from the same open source project to which I dedicated 10+ years of my life. In addition, many are still not aware that business can grow infinitely with open source," he continues.

This is the reason why it took a lot of time for screen reading programs to reach the maturity level of some proprietary alternatives, KK points out. Another challenge, according to him, is getting funds for open initiatives. Proprietary programs evolve well due to good financial resources.

India's position in the global FOSS ecosystem

Although there are very few 'Made in India' open source products (GNUKhata being one of the few), KK says many of individuals from India are being recognised worldwide. According to him, the health, education and finance

sectors are the forerunners in adopting FOSS in India.

As one of the measures to strengthen India's position in the global FOSS ecosystem, KK suggests that colleges should encourage interns to exclusively take up open source projects for their final year. By doing so, he believes, the country will be able to produce more FOSS-skilled human resources.

"The central/state governments can also play a huge role by using and implementing free software wherever it is possible. Not only does it save a lot of money (and thus reduce corruption), taxpayers' money is better utilised and there is total transparency. There should be IT related policies with budgets exclusively for open source," KK opines.

Advice to youngsters

To youngsters who are considering a career in FOSS technology, KK says, "Learn whatever you are learning right now, because there's a 99 per cent chance that it is all open source."

Interestingly, Big Data, cloud applications, Android based applications, object databases (like Mongo) and data science — all happen to be based on open source.

It is just that people are unaware that these are all open source technologies/platforms. Python and Java are open source, PHP is open source and so is MySQL. Audacity, the famous sound editing tool, is also the same.

KK advises youngsters to take advantage of these existing open source projects but also requests them to "...contribute back wherever possible."

The FOSS advocate concludes the conversation saying, "Open source is a challenge as well as a great opportunity." 

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